

"It is our first serious attempt to target the Chinese market."

AMBIKA SONI, MINISTER FOR TOURISM

choreographed by Leela Samson, who blended five different styles of classical Indian dance into a seamless spectacle that married the traditional with the modern, ideal for an audience unaware of what to expect.

India may not earn much space in the local media (unless it is to do with the Dalai Lama) and in the Middle Kingdom in general, but there is a latent curiosity about India. "Is Shah Rukh Khan performing tonight?" queried Mae Lee Chang, owner of a travel company who has never been to India but loves Bollywood movies, as do most Chinese. It was that curiosity which expanded a 700-member invitation list in Beijing and Shanghai to 900-plus, with requests for invitations posing a welcome diplomatic and protocol problem for the elegant and unflappable Nirupama Rao, India's ambassador to China. At the venue, Chinese girls in saris and salwar kameez welcomed arrivals with a practised *namaste* while handing out designer silk scarves. On a cold, wet and blustery evening in Beijing, the warmth was hard to miss.

Clearly no effort was being spared to woo an audience that represents a huge and largely virgin market. The way to a person's heart may be via the stomach but a dash of culture does no harm. In Beijing and Shanghai, they had both. Like her biblical namesake, Samson literally brought the house down. The Chinese make a big deal about hiding their emotions but there was no mistaking the genuine appreciation of the show, not to mention the elaborate spread of Indian food that followed. For one brief shining moment, India was truly incredible.

How long that moment lasts is anybody's guess. The potential is awesome—even one per cent of the 1.3-billion population, as Soni pointed out, represents a huge market and to get a slice of the Chinese takeaway, India is pulling out all the stops. Soni inaugurated the first India Tourism office in China, while week-long Indian food festivals in Beijing and Shanghai and involvement in building Buddhist



GLOBAL APPEAL: Soni (second from right) with Rao (left) at the inauguration

temples in places like Luoyang are all intended to raise India's profile in a China that is looking outward but so far mainly to the West.

Here's the rub, however. For a country where religious practice is a no-no, India's main tourist attraction is Buddhism, or more precisely, the Buddhist trail revolving around Bodhi Gaya. Tourism officials say that areas like the Golden Triangle are increasingly popular, but the numbers clearly indicate that India needs to hardsell itself more aggressively.

Like a typical Chinese banquet, where a variety of dishes are served before they bring on the rice and noodles, India is doing pretty much the same. Sponsored supplements on India have plastered the local media while the Incredible India website now has a Chinese version and the literature at the India Tourism office is available in Chinese. Local tour operators have been taken on familiarisation tours to India along with celebrity photographers like Rita Zhou, whose images of India formed part of the Incredible India charm offensive.

The ignorance about India in China is equally incredible, even among the intelligentsia. "Can you buy mineral water in India?" asks Lou Wei, the editor of a lifestyle magazine. Even the better informed seem to be more

aware of the negatives, like expensive hotels and lack of decent public transport. Then there is language and connectivity, "the two main constraints" according to S. Banerjee, the affable tourism secretary. Air India has just started operating a direct flight to Shanghai while China Air and China Eastern account for most of the 27 weekly flights that currently connect the two countries.

In Shanghai and Beijing, the designer stores, shopping malls, restaurants and fast food outlets in the more affluent areas symbolise China's economic miracle but also its obsession with the West. The only time a Chinese speaks of India with a tinge of envy is when he talks of Bangalore and its justifiably famed IT companies, most of which have operations in Shanghai. It is an indication that getting a thousand flowers to bloom, or its tourist equivalent, will be a tall order.

There is, however, guarded optimism in the upper echelons of the Tourism Ministry. Soni and her team of officials are generally on the ball as far as taking a liberal, innovative and non-bureaucratic approach to increasing footfalls from China. The Long March has only just begun and, if the charm offensive and raising awareness can be sustained, the Great Wall may not prove as formidable as it looks. ■